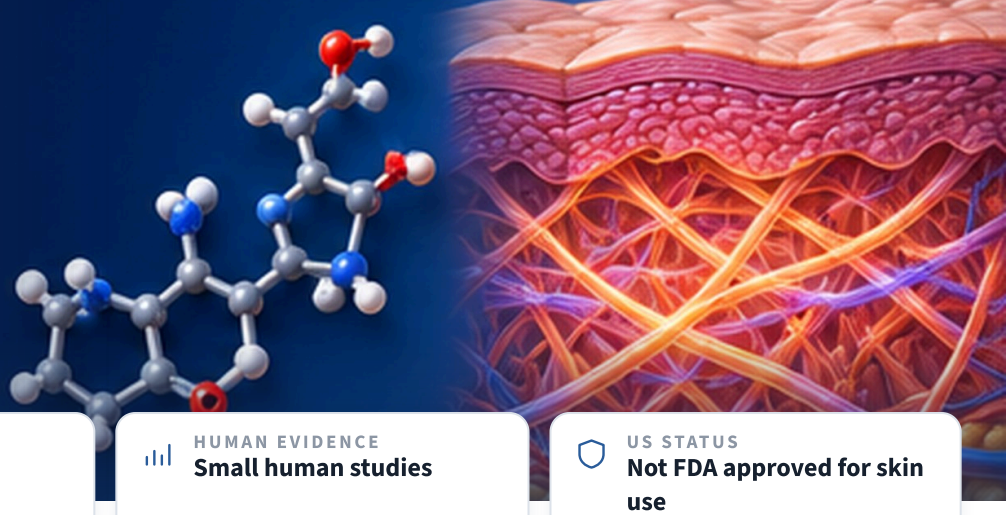
SKIN 03

Niacinamide

A vitamin (also called nicotinamide), a form of vitamin B3, applied to the skin as a gel or cream



CLASS Vitamin (topical)

STUDIED FOR Acne, oily skin

HUMAN EVIDENCE Small human studies

US STATUS Not FDA approved for skin use

STUDIED FOR

- **Acne** — HUMAN
- **Oily, blemish-prone** — HUMAN

No placebo groups. Both acne trials compared niacinamide gel with an antibiotic gel; none tested it combined with azelaic acid.

HOW IT WORKS IN THE BODY

Niacinamide → Skin → Not established → Acne lesions

- Niacinamide is a **vitamin**, listed in FDA-approved multivitamin injections
- **In people,** how it acts on the skin is not established
- **Cosmetic or drug:** FDA classes a skin product by its intended use and claims

EVIDENCE & WHAT'S KNOWN

EVIDENCE

SMALL HUMAN
LEVEL 3 OF 5

- 2 acne trials, 76 and 60 people, 8 weeks
- No difference vs clindamycin gel
- No placebo-controlled acne trial

NOT YET ESTABLISHED

- Long-term safety on skin
- Effect vs placebo
- Use with azelaic acid

QUICK PRACTICAL INFO

HALF-LIFE Not established for skin use

ROUTES STUDIED On the skin (gel, moisturizer)

PHARMACOKINETICS Not established for skin use

SOLD AS Cosmetics; compounded (Rx) creams

MONITORED IN TRIALS Acne lesion counts and severity, skin moisture

SPORT (WADA) Not on the 2026 list

REGULATORY

- **FDA** — Not approved for skin; only in multivitamins
- **FDA** — Compounded creams are not FDA approved
- **DEA** — Not a controlled substance
- **WADA** — Not on the 2026 list

REFERENCES

1. Shalita et al., Int J Dermatol, nicotinamide gel vs clindamycin gel, Jun 1995
2. Shahmoradi et al., J Res Med Sci, nicotinamide gel vs clindamycin gel, Feb 2013
3. FDA, Is it a cosmetic, a drug, or both?, Sep 2024

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